

for a day with Him means a thousand years. And He Himself is my witness, saying: ‘Behold, the day of the Lord shall be as a thousand years’.”¹

The author, whoever he was, is clearly claiming divine authorship for this quote which appears to be from 2 Peter 3:8.² In other words, 2 Peter is here regarded to be Scripture, as well as Matthew and Romans. Barnabas also has possible allusions to 1 and 2 Corinthians, Ephesians, Colossians, 1 and 2 Timothy, Titus, Hebrews, and 1 Peter.

The second century

The seven letters of Ignatius (c. AD 110) contain probable allusions to Matthew, John, Romans, 1 Corinthians and Ephesians (in his own letter to the Ephesians Ignatius says they are mentioned in “all the epistles of Paul”—a bit of hyperbole, but he was clearly aware of a Pauline corpus), and possible allusions to Luke, Acts, Galatians, Philippians, Colossians, 1 Thessalonians, 1 and 2 Timothy, and Titus, but very few are clear quotations and even they are not identified as such.

On the other hand, Polycarp, writing to the Philippian church (c. 115 AD?), weaves an almost continuous string of clear quotations and allusions to New Testament writings. His heavy use of Scripture is reminiscent of Clement of Rome; however, Clement used mostly the Old Testament while Polycarp mainly used the New. There are perhaps fifty clear quotations taken from Matthew, Luke, Acts, Romans, 1 and 2 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, 1 and 2 Thessalonians, 1 and 2 Timothy, 1 and 2 Peter, and 1 John, and many allusions including to Mark, Hebrews, James, and 2 and 3 John. (The only NT writer not included is Jude! But remember that the above refers to only one letter—if Polycarp wrote other letters he may well have quoted Jude.) **Please note that the idea of a NT ‘canon’ evidently already existed in 115 AD, and Polycarp’s ‘canon’ was quite similar to ours.**

His attitude toward the New Testament writings is clear from 12:1: “I am sure that you are well trained in the sacred Scriptures,... Now, as it is said in these Scriptures: ‘Be angry and sin not,’ and ‘Let not the sun go down upon your wrath.’ Blessed is he who remembers this.”³ Both parts

¹ I have used the translation done by Francis Glimm in *The Apostolic Fathers* (New York: Cima Publishing Co., Inc., 1947), belonging to the set, *The Fathers of the Church*, ed. Ludwig Schopp.

² J.V. Bartlet says of the formulae of citation used in Barnabas to introduce quotations from Scripture, “the general result is an absolute doctrine of inspiration”, but he is unwilling to consider that 2 Peter is being used. Oxford Society of Historical Research, *The New Testament in the Apostolic Fathers* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1905), pp. 2, 15.

³ Francis Glimm, again.